Cognitive Theories — Tyler & Conklin

Anthropological theories: (i) Cognitive theories (Tyler, Conklin) — ethnoscience · new ethnography · ethnosemantics

2 PYQs 1996 · 2002

dormant 24 years · Mains Value **Low** — but emic/etic was asked in 2015 (10M, Topic 7), and it feeds 6-G, 6-H, 6-J, the 2025 language question (15M) and Paper II jhum (2022)

THE ANSWER SPINE ① Culture is knowledge → ② Native categories → ③ Language and the emic → ④ Formal models → ⑤ Exemplars and limits

① WHAT IT IS — CULTURE AS KNOWLEDGE

2002 · note
1996 · "what is"

Goodenough 1957: a society's culture consists of **whatever one has to know or believe** in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its members.

Tyler 1969 (p. 3) — two questions: what material phenomena are **significant** for a people, and **how do they organise** them? Cultures are not material phenomena but **cognitive organisations of material phenomena**.

Names: ethnoscience (Sturtevant 1964: the system of knowledge and cognition typical of a culture) · new ethnography (Harris's critical label) · ethnosemantics · componential analysis · folk classification.

> **Roots** — Boas and the native's point of view · Sapir–Whorf (weak version: vocabulary shows what a culture distinguishes) · structural linguistics → **Pike 1954, emic/etic** from phonemic/phonetic · Goodenough 1956 and Lounsbury 1956 on kin terms · the Yale cohort: Conklin, Frake, Sturtevant.

Sits on the **ideational** side of American anthropology — against White, Steward and Harris.

② METHOD — WRITING THE CODE

1996 · "implications"
any 10M note

- **Elicitation frames** — "What kind of X is that?" (Frake 1962).
- **Domain** (things under a cover term) and **contrast set** (terms that exclude one another).
- **Folk taxonomy** — vertical, "kind of": plant › tree › oak › white oak. Ranks: unique beginner, life form, **generic** (most salient), specific, varietal (Berlin 1973).
- **Paradigm / componential analysis** — horizontal: each term a bundle of features (Wallace & Atkins 1960).

term	sex	gen.	lineality
father	male	+1	lineal
uncle	male	+1	colineal
brother	male	0	colineal
cousin	**none**	**any**	ablineal

- **Keys** — decision rules: Frake 1961, Subanun disease diagnosis.
- **Ethnography as grammar** — lets an outsider behave appropriately: "How to Ask for a Drink in Subanun" (Frake 1964).
- **Emics before comparison** — compare only units that are truly comparable (Tyler 1969).
- **Survivors:** free-lists, pile sorts, triads, consensus analysis (Weller & Romney 1988).

★ HERO — FROM NATIVE CATEGORIES TO A CULTURAL CODE

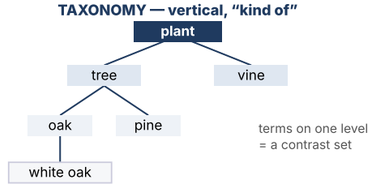
draw for any answer

① THE QUESTION
What phenomena are significant to them?
How do they organise them?
Tyler 1969 · Goodenough 1957
culture = what one must know

② THE METHOD
elicit native terms
→ contrast sets
→ taxonomy + paradigm
→ test against usage
phonemics → Pike's EMIC 1954

③ THE CLAIM
Cultures are cognitive organisations of material phenomena.
An ethnography is a **grammar of culture** (Frake, Subanun)

TAXONOMY — vertical, "kind of"



PARADIGM — horizontal, features

term	sex	gen.	lineality
father	male	+1	lineal
uncle	male	+1	colineal
cousin	—	any	ablineal

"uncle" differs from "father" on lineality only
"cousin" is unmarked for sex and generation

Wallace & Atkins 1960 · Goodenough 1956

③ CONKLIN (1926–2016) — THE CODE IS RICHER THAN OURS

named in syllabus
never in a stem

Hanunóo of Mindoro, Philippines (1947–58); later the **Ifugao** of Luzon.

- **The Relation of Hanunóo Culture to the Plant World** (PhD 1954): about **1,600 plant types** (1,625) — more than the botanists' species for the same flora, by 400+.
- **Hanunóo Agriculture** (FAO 1957): swidden as an **integral, rational system**; the term **ethnoecology**.
- "Lexicographical Treatment of Folk Taxonomies" (1962) · *Ethnographic Atlas of Ifugao* (1980).

> **Use:** proof that indigenous knowledge is systematic → TEK, Paper II jhum (2022, 15M): P. S. Ramakrishnan 1992 on Meghalaya.

Hanunóo Color Categories (1955) — four terms, two dimensions:



Deficient on a spectral chart, exact once you see it is **built for plants**.

④ TYLER (1932–2020) — DEFINER TURNED CRITIC

named in syllabus
bridge → 6-J

Koya of the Godavari valley, Andhra Pradesh — *Koya: An Outline Grammar* (Gommu, 1969); *India: An Anthropological Perspective* (1973).

1965–66	1969	1978	1986
Koya kin terms vary by **context** — no single paradigm fits usage	*Cognitive Anthropology* — the reader that named the field; "Myth of P"	*The Said and the Unsaid* — meaning in context and the unsaid	"Post-Modern Ethnography" in *Writing Culture* — **evoke**, not represent

> **Line:** Tyler's career is the arc of the school — he defined it in 1969, found in Koya usage that meaning escapes formal paradigms, and by 1986 argued ethnography can only evoke.

⑤ LIMITS, LATER PHASES, INDIA

1996 · "critically"

Burling 1964 — "God's Truth or Hocus-Pocus?" several componential solutions fit the same terms; which is in the native's head? **Psychological reality** unproven.

Geertz 1973 — the "cognitivist fallacy", quoting Tyler: culture is **public** because meaning is (→ 6-H).

Harris 1968 — "new ethnography": emics without etics; describes, cannot explain (→ 6-G).

Also: narrow, word-bound domains (kin, colour, plants, disease) · tacit and embodied knowledge missed (Bloch) · no variation or power · static · elicitation artefacts.

Counter-case — Berlin & Kay 1969: eleven basic colour terms in a **fixed sequence** (black/white → red → green/yellow → blue → brown → rest). A relativist method produced **universals**. Then Rosch's prototypes; Holland & Quinn 1987 cultural models; Romney et al. 1986 consensus; Hutchins 1995.

India: Tyler's Koya · Dravidian cross/parallel terms (Dumont 1953; Trautmann 1981) · S. K. Jain's ethnobotany · PBRs (2002), TKDL (2001) · hot/cold illness categories.

Traps: Tyler ≠ Tylor · emic/etic is Pike's, not Harris's · Conklin worked in the Philippines, not India.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE As a theory of culture it was too narrow — culture is not only in heads, not only in words, and not one code for everyone. As a **method** it survived, and its proof that "primitive" knowledge is **systematic** — Conklin's Hanunóo out-classifying the botanists — is now the premise of respect for traditional ecological knowledge. Its own definer, Tyler, became its sharpest critic and carried the argument into postmodernism.